setback'. Interestingly, the Taliban (similar to Rabbani in 1992) had sent 'feelers' to engage with India. Mullah Muttawakil sent the first feeler on 23 October 1996 in his interview to the Pakistani journalist Rahimullah Yusufzai, which was published by the *Outlook Magazine* in India. A key member of the ruling central Shura of the Taliban, Muttawakil stated:

> We [Taliban] certainly can have better ties with New Delhi if India stops interfering in Afghanistan and assures us that Afghanistan's embassy in New Delhi will not be allowed to be used against the Taliban by Rabbani's appointees there.[136]

Muttawakil wondered 'what has the Taliban done to attract Indian ire?' Frustrated over India's unrealistic Afghanistan policy, Muttawakil argued that New Delhi must be required to know 'a lot more about Afghanistan' so as to formulate a successful policy. Critically, when asked about the Taliban's views on Kashmir and the conditions of Muslims in India, Muttawakil responded (again, similarly to Rabbani in 1992): 'For the moment, we won't say anything ... We want friendly ties with neighbours and have no intention of either interfering in affairs of other countries or allowing them to interfere in our affairs.'[137] Though wanting to engage, the Taliban's proposal came with conditions attached. It wanted New Delhi to cut all ties with Rabbani and throw its weight behind the Taliban.

The second signal came on 11 June 1997, before the Taliban's retreat from Mazar-e-Sharif. This time it was Mullah Abdul Jalil, deputy foreign minister of the Taliban, who wanted India to stop treating the Taliban as an enemy. Phrases used by both Muttawakil and Jalil were similar in their criticism of India's Afghanistan policy. Talking from a position of strength, Jalil said:

> We can consider forging mutually beneficial ties with India if it brings positive changes in its Afghanistan policy ... The Taliban wants friendly ties with all countries, both Islamic and non-Islamic. With our neighbours, including India, we would like to have normal relations based on the policy of non-interference. Until now, India has been interfering in Afghanistan's affairs. We want this interference to end. In fact, we will be waiting for signs that indicate a change of heart in New Delhi.[138]

Former Indian Foreign Secretary K. Raghunath (July 1997 to November 1999), a staunch anti-Taliban partisan, confirms that India did not entertain the two feelers. The question was often put that if the Taliban makes overtures, which they did, should India talk to them? 'And the answer is no, because we don't get anything by talking to them', says Raghunath.[139] A 1962-batch diplomat,